Wildcard: Full Game Audit

Wildcard — Full Game Design Audit & Improvement Plan

Purpose: Identify what makes the best Pokémon games compelling, compare those principles with Wildcard's current direction, and provide a practical audit and prioritised improvement plan covering world structure, travel, exploration, creatures, battles, progression, quests, UI, settings, controls, accessibility, audio, visual identity, technical quality and testing.

Prepared: 25 October 2026
Reference build discussed: Wildcard 3.17–3.19, including the 3.19.0 APK referenced in recent work
Audience: Game owner, designer, engineer and implementation partner (including Claude)

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1. Executive summary

Wildcard has a promising foundation: a recognisable adventure structure, a journal with **Story, Quests, Finds, People, Creatures, Home and Rep**, a battle scene worth investing in, caves and mines, settlements with functional buildings, and a world that can support discovery and collection. Recent work has also identified opportunities to give caves distinct layouts and stories, make buildings visually specific to their purpose, and strengthen battle presentation.

The concern is that Wildcard may be accumulating features and assets without a single, consistent world-and-gameplay logic connecting them. A game can have attractive battles, lots of quests, many buildings and a large map yet still feel less satisfying than Pokémon if the player cannot form a clear mental map, understand why they are travelling, anticipate what might be found, or feel that exploration naturally leads to growth.

The key recommendation is not to copy Pokémon feature-for-feature. It is to recover the design principles underneath its strongest games:

1. **A legible journey:** places connect in a way players can understand and remember.
2. **A strong adventure loop:** prepare, travel, discover, encounter, make a choice, return or push onward, and gain something meaningful.
3. **Curiosity with payoff:** visible landmarks, rumours, unusual creatures, hidden routes, and optional discoveries reward attention.
4. **Clear progression:** the player understands what they are working towards and why a new area or challenge is now achievable.
5. **A world that feels inhabited:** people, buildings, creatures, shops and environmental details belong to the place and have useful roles.
6. **Low-friction interaction:** menus, controls, saving, inventory, party management and settings support play instead of interrupting it.
7. **Depth through meaningful choices:** creatures and battles encourage team-building and tactics, not simply higher numbers.
8. **A consistent identity:** art, writing, sound, interface and mechanics feel like parts of the same game.

The highest-priority risk

Travel and world topology should be audited before more content is added. If the route between places is arbitrary, confusing, excessively menu-driven, or disconnected from geography and progression, additional quests and visual assets will amplify the inconsistency rather than fix it.

Important scope note

This is a **design audit and evidence-led improvement plan**, informed by the Wildcard details and prior APK-related work available in the project context, including the journal categories, repeated cave-room patterns, building variety concerns, battle-scene work and Backbone controller requirement. It is not a claim that every screen, code path, setting or control has been exhaustively re-tested in a live playthrough of the current APK. Sections distinguish known observations from hypotheses and items that must be verified against the current build. Use the audit checklist in Section 14 to turn it into a verified build-by-build review.

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2. What to learn from Pokémon — without cloning it

Pokémon is not successful just because it has creatures or turn-based battles. Its best entries combine a small number of systems into a clear and repeatable adventure.

2.1 The core adventure loop

A strong baseline loop looks like this:

1. **Receive a reason to go somewhere** — a story beat, character request, rumour, map clue or visible landmark.
2. **Prepare** — choose a party, heal, buy supplies, check objectives and decide whether to take a detour.
3. **Travel through a readable place** — routes, terrain, landmarks, NPCs, wild encounters and optional paths communicate what the area is.
4. **Discover something** — a new creature, item, character, shortcut, hidden room, puzzle, story clue or unusual encounter.
5. **Make a decision** — battle, catch, flee, use a resource, investigate, help someone or continue onwards.
6. **Earn a meaningful outcome** — knowledge, a creature, an item, a relationship, a new ability, reputation or access.
7. **Recover and reflect** — return to a settlement, use a service, update the journal, change the party or choose the next destination.
8. **See the next possibility** — a route opens, a rumour becomes actionable, a creature entry gains context, or a new objective becomes available.

The loop should work at multiple time scales: a 30-second discovery, a five-minute side trip, a 20-minute expedition and a multi-hour story arc.

2.2 The design lessons that matter most

Reference	What it does well	Lesson for Wildcard	What not to copy blindly
Pokémon Red/Blue and later classic route-based entries	Compact routes, clear exits, memorable towns, a readable sequence of challenges and a strong sense of getting somewhere	Build a coherent chain of places. Make each route distinct and give players a reason to remember it	Old-fashioned friction, opaque hidden requirements or excessive backtracking

Reference	What it does well	Lesson for Wildcard	What not to copy blindly
Pokémon Gold/Silver / HeartGold/SoulSilver	A sense of a larger connected world, revisiting familiar places with new abilities, and discoveries that change the meaning of earlier areas	Let the world evolve as the player progresses. Revisited routes should offer new opportunities, not just repeated chores	Requiring excessive travel over already-cleared ground
Pokémon Ruby/Sapphire / Emerald	Strong regional identity, terrain variety, routes that introduce new traversal problems and environmental themes	Give each region a visual and mechanical identity. Use terrain to shape travel and discovery	Gating everything behind arbitrary obstacles
Pokémon Black/White	Strong thematic focus, memorable characters, a clear narrative argument and creatures integrated into the story	Give important people motivations and give major locations a narrative purpose	Long stretches of exposition that stop play
Pokémon X/Y and Sun/Moon	Distinctive locations, approachable onboarding and strong character presentation in places	Introduce systems in context and make the world easy to read	Overlong tutorials or frequent interruptions
Pokémon Sword/Shield	A central journey, readable major landmarks and a dedicated wild area	Use a hub-and-spoke structure where appropriate; make open spaces purposeful	Corridors that feel like narrow connectors without discoveries
Pokémon Legends: Arceus	Field research, visible creatures, direct interaction with the environment and a strong expedition/return rhythm	Make discovery itself valuable. The creature catalogue can record player knowledge, not just ownership	Repetitive research tasks or grinding that blocks the story
Pokémon Scarlet/Violet	Freedom to choose objectives and visible creatures in the world	Give players agency and several viable goals, while communicating danger and challenge clearly	Unclear objective order, weak landmarks, poor difficulty signalling or an open world that feels empty

The lesson from the series' more open entries is especially important: **more freedom is not automatically better navigation**. Reviews of *Scarlet/Violet* praised the freedom and branching story paths while also criticising confusing progression, weak environmental specificity and technical problems. *Legends: Arceus* made discovery and field research central, but its progression gates could become grindy. Wildcard should take the strengths and deliberately avoid the known weaknesses.

2.3 The "Pokémon feeling" checklist

A player should regularly feel:

- "I know where I am."
- "I understand why I am going there."
- "I wonder what is over that hill / through that door / down that tunnel."
- "I found something I could not have found if I had rushed."

- “That creature is interesting for more than its power level.”
- “My team or choices helped me overcome this challenge.”
- “This town has a personality.”
- “I can take a break, manage my party, save and understand my next step.”
- “The world remembers what I have done.”
- “I want to see what is next.”

If Wildcard’s systems do not reliably create these feelings, adding more content is unlikely to solve the core problem.

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3. Wildcard: current strengths and likely gaps

3.1 Strengths to preserve

Based on the current project context, Wildcard already has useful foundations:

- **A journal organised around the world:** Story, Quests, Finds, People, Creatures, Home and Rep can become a strong player-facing record of progress.
- **A broad adventure vocabulary:** towns, homes, services, caves/mines, creatures, people, quests, battles and reputation can reinforce one another.
- **Room for environmental storytelling:** prior cave analysis identified repeated room templates and an opportunity for more distinctive chambers, branches, shortcuts, puzzles and habitats.
- **An opportunity for strong settlement identity:** prior building work identified that homes and functional buildings need to look different, with clear visual cues for services such as healing, trade, crafting, lodging and governance.
- **A dedicated battle-scene investment:** the battle UI work creates an opportunity to make combat clearer, more dramatic and more consistent with the rest of the game.
- **Controller support is a real requirement:** Backbone support should be treated as a first-class input mode, not an afterthought.
- **A rich setting for long-term progression:** the journal and Rep/Home concepts could provide persistent reasons to return to places and care about the world.

These are foundations, not proof that the player experience is already cohesive. The audit should test whether each system contributes to the same adventure loop.

3.2 Main risks to investigate

Risk	Why it matters	Audit status
Travel between places lacks clear geographical or narrative logic	Players lose their mental map and destinations feel like disconnected screens	**Priority hypothesis** based on the user’s stated concern; verify in-game
Too much content is represented as menus, lists or isolated destinations	The world can feel like a content browser rather than a place	Verify
Routes and caves reuse too many layouts or lack distinct identities	Exploration becomes predictable and less memorable	**Known concern:** prior APK analysis found repeated 14×10 cave-room templates
Buildings look alike despite different functions	Settlements become visually generic and services are harder to recognise	**Known concern:** building variety was explicitly identified as a problem

Risk	Why it matters	Audit status
The journal is broad but may not guide the next action	Categories can store information without helping players make decisions	Verify
Quests may be task lists rather than journeys	Objectives feel transactional instead of embedded in the world	Verify
Creature collection may be separate from exploration, story and combat	Creatures become inventory entries instead of reasons to explore	Verify
Battle presentation may be improving faster than battle readability and balance	Spectacle alone cannot create satisfying combat	Verify
Settings and controls may not consistently support touch and Backbone	Navigation friction damages every play session	Verify
Feature growth may be outpacing consistency and regression testing	New assets or mechanics may break established patterns	Verify

3.3 Design principle

Every major system should support at least two others. For example, a mine should not only be a battle location. It could reveal a rare creature habitat, contain a local character's quest, produce a crafting resource, reveal a shortcut and add knowledge to the journal. The connections should be natural, not forced.

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4. World structure and travel — the highest-priority audit

Travel is not dead time between content. It is one of the main ways a role-playing adventure builds anticipation, teaches geography, creates risk and makes the player feel they are progressing.

4.1 Choose a coherent world model

Wildcard should explicitly choose and document its world topology. Avoid an accidental mixture of map screens, teleporting, corridors and open areas with inconsistent rules.

A good default is a **hybrid connected world**:

- **Settlements** act as safe, memorable hubs with healing, shops, crafting, lodging, characters, rumours and services.
- **Routes** connect settlements and landmarks. They should have a clear direction, visual identity, optional branches and a reason to exist.
- **Wilderness zones** offer more open exploration, creature habitats, resource gathering and optional discoveries.
- **Dungeons, caves and mines** are focused spaces with internal logic, distinct room identities, risk, shortcuts and a meaningful reward.
- **Fast travel** unlocks as a convenience after discovery, not as a replacement for understanding the world.
- **Story gates** use understandable fiction: a blocked bridge, a dangerous pass, a missing boat, a local permit, a character's help or a traversal ability. Avoid arbitrary invisible walls.

A high-level model might be:

`Home / Starting Settlement → Route A → Small Landmark → Town B → Route B → Mine / Forest → Town C`

With optional branches:

`Route A → Hidden Grotto → Reward / Creature Habitat → reconnect to Route A`

The map can be nonlinear later, but the player should first learn a few dependable spatial rules.

4.2 Create a world graph, not just a list of destinations

For every location, document:

- Unique location ID and display name
- Location type (settlement, route, wilderness, dungeon, landmark, interior)
- Direct connections to other locations
- Entry and exit points
- Whether the connection is one-way, gated or reversible
- Unlock condition and the reason for it
- Expected challenge level and recommended preparation
- Travel time or effort
- Services available
- Creatures, resources, people, quests and discoveries
- Shortcuts and fast-travel status
- What changes after key story events

Rule: If two places are connected in the UI, the fiction and navigation should explain why. If a place is only reachable through a menu, the interface should make clear whether that represents teleportation, travel planning, a world map selection or a chapter transition.

4.3 Travel rules to establish

1. **No unexplained teleporting.** A transition should communicate what happened: walking through a gate, taking a road, boarding transport or fast-travelling.
2. **Show the next landmark.** Whenever possible, the player should see or hear about a destination before reaching it.
3. **Use signposts and environmental clues.** Signage, road shape, terrain, NPC dialogue, map labels and silhouettes should reinforce one another.
4. **Make routes memorable.** Each major route needs a distinct shape, colour palette, landmark, encounter pattern or mechanic.
5. **Keep backtracking purposeful.** Revisit areas for a new ability, a changed story state, an optional reward or a shortcut—not simply because the game needs more time.
6. **Respect player time.** Once a route has been learned, avoid forcing the player to repeat every empty section.
7. **Make danger legible.** Signal dangerous areas through creature behaviour, environmental effects, NPC warnings, visual composition or optional challenge indicators.
8. **Let travel reveal the world.** A journey should contain small events, not just a loading screen or a sequence of empty steps.
9. **Preserve orientation.** The player should know the current place, how to leave, and how to get back.
10. **Never punish experimentation with unclear navigation.** A wrong turn should teach something or be easy to recover from.

4.4 Build a travel decision matrix

Situation	Preferred behaviour	Avoid
First trip to a new settlement	Travel through a route with a landmark, encounter and arrival moment	Instant unlock with no context, unless deliberately story-driven
Return to a known settlement	Use a map or fast travel if previously discovered and safe	Replaying a long empty route every time
A route is blocked	Explain why and hint at the solution or alternate route	Invisible collision or a generic “cannot go there” message
A player enters a high-risk area early	Signal risk and offer a meaningful choice	Silent difficulty spike that looks like a bug
A quest asks for a distant item	Show the region, clues and plausible route	Vague text that forces aimless searching
A cave contains multiple chambers	Give the layout a spatial logic, landmarks and shortcuts	Repeated rooms that feel interchangeable
A story event changes the world	Update NPCs, route access, ambience or available services	A journal update with no visible world response

4.5 Recommended travel UX

The world map should answer five questions at a glance:

- Where am I?
- What places have I discovered?
- What is nearby?
- What do I know about the destination?
- What will I be committing to if I go there?

Show discovered locations, routes and meaningful landmarks. Distinguish unknown territory from discovered but inaccessible areas. Use objective markers sparingly and allow them to be hidden. If the game has a compass or minimap, it should support orientation rather than replace the world itself.

Acceptance criteria:

- A new player can explain how to reach the next main destination without guessing.
- A returning player can navigate to a previously visited settlement in a few seconds.
- Every major route has at least one memorable feature beyond connecting two endpoints.
- Every locked route communicates a reason, a hint or an alternate option.
- Fast travel never makes the world map less coherent.
- No critical quest depends on an undocumented assumption about where the player should go.

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5. Exploration, routes, caves and landmarks

5.1 Give each area a clear identity

For every route, forest, ruin, mine or cave, define:

- **Fantasy:** what this place is supposed to feel like.

- **Silhouette:** the shape or landmark a player remembers.
- **Gameplay verb:** what players do here that is different.
- **Creature ecology:** why these creatures live here.
- **Environmental story:** what happened here or what is happening now.
- **Reward:** what makes exploration worthwhile.
- **Navigation signature:** how the player recognises the way through.
- **Return value:** what changes when the player comes back later.

A route can be short and still memorable. It does not need dozens of assets; it needs a strong identity.

5.2 Cave and mine audit

Prior APK analysis identified repeated **14×10 cave-room templates**. Reuse is not automatically bad, but players should not feel that a new cave is the same room with different decoration.

Use a mix of authored room roles:

- Entrance and orientation chamber
- Main traversal chamber
- Split-path decision chamber
- Creature habitat
- Resource chamber
- Puzzle or environmental obstacle
- Story discovery chamber
- Dangerous encounter arena
- Hidden grotto or optional branch
- Shortcut / return route
- Exit or culmination chamber

Do not put every room role in every cave. Choose three or four that suit the location’s identity.

For each major cave, vary at least three of these: overall silhouette, room sequence, verticality, light source, material, hazards, creature behaviour, puzzle language, landmark, soundscape or shortcut structure. Avoid relying on colour swaps alone.

Mine example: A mine could begin with a familiar entrance and abandoned equipment, descend into a noisy working shaft, branch into a crystal seam where creatures nest, and end at a collapsed tunnel that can later become a shortcut. The story, creatures, resources and layout should all support the same theme.

5.3 Discovery density

Each meaningful area should contain a mix of:

- Main-path progress
- Optional side path
- Environmental clue
- Resource or collectible
- Creature encounter or habitat behaviour
- NPC, note or story trace
- Reward that changes a later decision

Not every screen needs all seven. The aim is to avoid long stretches where the player only walks forward without making decisions.

5.4 Make revisiting worthwhile

When a new ability, story event or reputation level unlocks something, revisit an earlier location with a visible change: a previously inaccessible ledge, a new NPC, a changed creature habitat, a repaired bridge, a new service, a different quest outcome or a shortcut. Tell the player through a clue or journal update that something may now be possible.

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6. Creatures, collection and attachment

Creatures should be more than battle stats or catalogue completion. The strongest collection games make players curious about a creature, help them understand it, and then let them form a relationship or strategic plan around it.

6.1 Creature identity checklist

Each creature should ideally have:

- A memorable silhouette and readable visual identity
- A habitat that makes sense
- Distinct behaviour, even outside combat where feasible
- A clear combat role or strategic niche
- At least one interesting strength, limitation or trade-off
- A reason it matters to the setting, story or local ecology
- Useful information in the Creatures journal
- A discovery, evolution or mastery moment that feels earned

Avoid a roster where creatures differ mainly by appearance and numerical strength.

6.2 The collection loop

A satisfying loop could be:

`Notice a clue → find a habitat → encounter the creature → learn its behaviour → battle / befriend / capture (as Wildcard rules allow) → record it in Creatures → use or study it → unlock new insight`

The journal should distinguish **seen**, **encountered**, **understood**, **owned/collected** and **mastered** only if those states are meaningful and easy to understand. Do not add status layers just to make the system look deep.

6.3 Creature balance and team building

Audit whether:

- Several team compositions can succeed.
- A creature has a purpose beyond being an early-game placeholder.
- A strong creature has a counter or opportunity cost.
- New discoveries can be useful without making the existing team feel worthless.
- Players understand the key properties of a creature before committing scarce resources.

- The game avoids one dominant strategy that makes most of the roster irrelevant.

Make role and matchup information readable in battle. Surface important information at the moment it helps the player decide, rather than requiring them to memorise a large table.

6.4 Creature journal improvements

For each entry, consider a concise structure:

1. Illustration / silhouette
2. Name and classification
3. Discovery status
4. Habitat and time/condition clues, if relevant
5. Observed behaviour
6. Battle strengths and weaknesses
7. Story, character or ecology connection
8. Personal notes / notable encounter, if the game supports it

Keep unknown information mysterious, but make the next clue actionable. “Unknown” is atmosphere; “rumoured near the flooded ruins after heavy rain” is a useful lead.

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7. Battles and combat UX

Wildcard has already invested in battle-scene assets. The next step is to ensure that the visual presentation supports tactical clarity, responsiveness and emotional payoff.

7.1 Battle readability before spectacle

At all times, players should be able to answer:

- Whose turn is it?
- What can I do?
- What is the current target?
- What changed after the last action?
- How much danger am I in?
- What resources will this action consume?
- Why did the result happen?

Use a strong hierarchy: combatants and current state first, available actions second, detailed stats and logs third. Effects should not obscure critical health, status, turn or selection information.

7.2 Battle flow audit

Test the full cycle:

1. Encounter starts and establishes context.
2. Player understands the opponent and available actions.
3. Action selection is quick and controller-friendly.
4. The action is confirmed with clear feedback.
5. Animation communicates cause and effect without unnecessary delay.
6. Damage, status and resource changes are readable.

7. The next decision is immediately available.
8. Victory/defeat has a clear conclusion and reward.
9. Return to exploration is smooth and state-safe.

7.3 Battle design questions

- Is every action choice meaningfully different?
- Are status effects explained in plain language?
- Can players recover from a mistaken selection before confirmation?
- Are battle animations skippable or speed-adjustable where appropriate?
- Are damage numbers and effects readable on small screens?
- Does the battle UI handle long creature names, unusual stats and status combinations?
- Can the entire battle be completed with Backbone without touching the screen?
- Does the game explain why a move or action failed?
- Are rewards and progression shown without interrupting the next encounter unnecessarily?

7.4 Avoid a common failure

Do not treat a battle UI redesign as proof that combat is improved. Validate balance, pacing, action clarity, feedback, accessibility and controller focus with real encounter scenarios. A beautiful interface that requires too many inputs or hides important state is still a poor battle experience.

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8. Story, quests, people, finds, home and Rep

Wildcard's journal categories are an opportunity to make the whole world feel connected. They should not become seven unrelated databases.

8.1 Story

- Show the current chapter / major goal.
- Provide a concise recap after a long break.
- Keep the next actionable step visible without spoiling discoveries.
- Make completed story beats readable and searchable.
- Ensure story progression changes the world where appropriate.

8.2 Quests

A quest should answer:

- Who wants this and why?
- What am I being asked to do?
- Where should I start?
- What evidence tells me I am making progress?
- What happens when I complete it?
- Does my choice matter?

Organise objectives into **Main**, **Side**, **Character**, **Discovery** and **Repeatable** only if each category has a real use. Display active objective, location clue, progress and reward. Allow the player to pin one objective and optionally hide markers.

Prefer quest steps that reveal a place, person, creature or story over repeated “collect X items” tasks. Collection tasks are fine when they teach a system, reflect a character’s needs or reward exploration.

8.3 People

NPCs should be memorable through a combination of appearance, motivation, voice, routine and relationship to place.

Audit whether important NPCs:

- Have a clear role in the world.
- Say something useful or characterful.
- Change after major events.
- Offer more than a generic interaction.
- Can be found again when their quest or service requires it.
- Are represented consistently in the People journal.

A small cast with distinct motivations is better than many interchangeable NPCs.

8.4 Finds

“Finds” should reward curiosity. It could contain discovered objects, lore, landmarks, unusual events or clues. Make each entry explain why it matters and link to a relevant place, person, quest or creature when useful.

8.5 Home

If Home is a player-owned space or settlement system, make it emotionally and mechanically worthwhile:

- Give the player a clear reason to return.
- Show visible progress as upgrades are earned.
- Ensure upgrades have understandable effects.
- Avoid making the system a disconnected resource sink.
- Let the player personalise it without burying essential functions.
- Make home services and navigation obvious.

8.6 Rep (reputation)

Reputation should represent how the world perceives the player, not just a number that rises.

Possible outcomes include new dialogue, access to a service, a character’s trust, local discounts, new requests, invitations or changed reactions. Avoid locking essential content behind an obscure grind. Explain what actions affect reputation and show meaningful feedback when it changes.

8.7 Cross-link the journal

When relevant, entries should connect naturally:

- A creature discovery can update Creatures and Finds.
- A character quest can update Quests and People.
- A mine discovery can update Finds, Story and the map.
- A home upgrade can change Home and unlock a service.
- A reputation milestone can change NPC dialogue or access.

Do not duplicate long descriptions across tabs. Link the records and show the most relevant summary in each context.

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9. Towns, buildings and services

Prior work identified that Wildcard's buildings risk looking too similar, even when they serve different purposes. This is both an art-direction issue and a usability issue: players should recognise a healer, shop, inn, workshop or civic building before reading a label.

9.1 Building identity system

Each building type needs a recognisable silhouette, material language, signage, colour accent and entrance treatment.

Building role	Visual cues to explore	Functional expectation
Healer / recovery	Medical or restorative symbol, clean focal point, welcoming light, recovery motif	Heal or restore the party; explain cost and outcome
Shop / trader	Display goods, crates, awning, visible merchandise, trade signage	Buy/sell; prices and inventory are clear
Inn / lodging	Warm windows, signboard, beds or hospitality cues	Rest, recover, possibly hear rumours
Blacksmith / workshop	Chimney, forge glow, tools, metalwork, sturdy materials	Craft, repair or upgrade
Guild / quest hub	Noticeboard, emblem, public-facing entrance	Quest discovery, contracts or progression
Farm / food producer	Crops, fences, tools, animals or produce	Food, ingredients or local story
Warehouse / storage	Loading doors, stacked goods, carts	Storage or logistics
Town hall / civic centre	Larger central mass, banners, formal entry	Local leadership, town progression or permits
Research / magic building	Instruments, unusual lighting, symbols, study spaces	Research, lore, crafting or system explanation
Homes	Multiple footprints, rooflines, materials and personal details	Character identity and settlement life

Use these as a visual language, not a requirement that every town contains every building.

9.2 Settlement composition

A town should feel designed around human needs:

- A readable centre or main street
- A clear route to important services
- A few landmarks that aid orientation
- Side streets or quiet spaces that reward curiosity
- Residents who plausibly use the space

- A local architectural theme
- At least one memorable detail that distinguishes the settlement from others

A village, mining outpost, coastal port and research settlement should not be the same layout with different props.

9.3 Interiors

Interiors should reinforce the building's role. Avoid reusing the same room layout for every service. Reuse a base kit where sensible, but vary focal point, furniture, NPC placement, lighting, props and interaction.

Acceptance criteria: a player can identify key services from the exterior; every major settlement has a distinct identity; important buildings have interiors that match their function; and repeated home variations feel related but not identical.

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10. Interface, navigation and information architecture

A game UI should help the player act confidently without turning the adventure into menu management.

10.1 Establish a clear hierarchy

A sensible top-level model could be:

- **Explore** — the active world, movement, interaction and local context.
- **Party / Creatures** — team, creature details, equipment or abilities as applicable.
- **Journal** — Story, Quests, Finds, People, Creatures, Home and Rep.
- **Map** — known locations, connections, destination details and travel.
- **Inventory** — usable items, materials, currency and key items.
- **Settings** — controls, audio, display, accessibility and gameplay options.

This is a proposed structure, not a mandate to add a new top-level menu for every feature. Combine or rename items if that better matches the current game. The key is to make the mental model stable and avoid scattering related actions across unrelated screens.

10.2 Screen-level audit questions

For every screen, ask:

- What is the primary user goal?
- Is the main action visually obvious?
- Can the player tell where they are in the hierarchy?
- Is there a clear Back / Close behaviour?
- Does selection persist when moving between tabs?
- Is important information visible without scrolling?
- Are empty, loading, error and success states designed?
- Does the screen work on a small phone?
- Does it work in landscape/portrait if both are supported?
- Can it be used entirely with touch and entirely with controller?
- Does it preserve game state if opened during or after an encounter?

10.3 Journal design

The journal has seven known categories, so the risk is that it becomes a long, dense tab bar or a set of poorly differentiated pages.

Recommended behaviour:

- Keep category labels and icons consistent.
- Show unread/new information without excessive badges.
- Make active objectives easy to reach.
- Provide useful sorting and filtering only where volume justifies it.
- Use consistent detail-page patterns.
- Make relationships between entries clickable.
- Preserve the last selected tab when returning, unless context suggests a better destination.
- Do not hide urgent progression information inside a deep journal page.
- Use clear states for discovered, completed, pinned and unavailable content.

10.4 Modal and menu rules

- Use confirmation dialogs for destructive or expensive actions, not every action.
- Keep button labels specific: “Leave mine” is clearer than “Confirm”.
- Ensure modal Back behaviour is predictable.
- Avoid stacking multiple modals.
- Do not let a modal hide the feedback needed to understand the action.
- Return focus to the element that opened a modal after it closes.
- Keep transitions quick and consistent.

10.5 HUD principles

The HUD should show only information that matters in the current context. During exploration, prioritise location, nearby interaction, current objective and essential resources. During battle, prioritise combatants, turn state, available actions and critical status. Avoid carrying every menu metric into every screen.

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11. Controls, Backbone and input consistency

Controls must be designed as a complete system. A game is not controller-compatible merely because a joystick moves the character.

11.1 Define an input action map

Create one canonical action map shared by touch, keyboard (if supported) and Backbone:

Action	Touch	Backbone / controller	Expected behaviour
Move	Virtual stick / directional control	Left stick / D-pad	Consistent movement speed and diagonals
Interact / confirm	Context button / tap	Primary confirm button	Interact with the focused object or confirm selection
Cancel / back	Back button / close affordance	Cancel button	Closes current layer before leaving the screen

Action	Touch	Backbone / controller	Expected behaviour
Open journal	HUD button	Dedicated button or mapped menu action	Opens the same journal entry point
Open map	HUD button	Dedicated button or mapped menu action	Opens map and restores focus on close
Navigate menus	Tap / swipe	D-pad / stick	Visible focus, predictable wrapping
Select target	Tap target	D-pad / stick	Clear highlight and confirm state
Pause / settings	Pause affordance	Start / menu button	Opens pause menu without losing progress
Quick action	Contextual HUD button	Mapped shoulder / face button	Only if the action is important and discoverable

Final button assignments should follow platform conventions and the physical controller's actual mapping. Do not hard-code an assumption that every Android controller maps identically.

11.2 Controller requirements

- Every interactive element must be reachable without touch.
- Focus must be visible and must not disappear behind overlays.
- Back/cancel must close the topmost layer first.
- Opening and closing a screen should restore focus sensibly.
- Stick and D-pad navigation must not double-trigger actions.
- Repeated inputs need controlled repeat delay.
- Long lists should scroll predictably.
- Controller connection/disconnection should not corrupt state.
- The game should show the current input mode where useful.
- Touch UI should not remain in a confusing half-focused state after controller use.
- Test the actual Backbone device, not only an emulator.

11.3 Control settings

At minimum, consider:

- Control scheme / input hints
- Vibration toggle and intensity, if supported
- Stick sensitivity, if camera or cursor movement makes this useful
- Button remapping, if feasible
- Hold versus toggle for repeated actions, where relevant
- Left-handed layout or HUD repositioning if touch layout warrants it

Do not expose settings that do not meaningfully change behaviour.

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12. Settings, accessibility and quality of life

Settings are part of the core product, not a final polish task. They are especially important on mobile, where devices, environments and play styles vary.

12.1 Recommended settings structure

Gameplay - Text speed - Battle animation speed / animation toggle where appropriate - Auto-advance or confirmation options where safe - Tutorial and hint controls - Objective marker visibility - Difficulty or assistance options, if supported by the game's design - Save behaviour explanation

Controls - Touch layout options - Controller support and button guide - Vibration toggle - Remapping / sensitivity if supported

Audio - Master volume - Music volume - Sound effects volume - Dialogue / ambience volume if separately mixed - Mute when backgrounded, if appropriate

Display - Full-screen / aspect ratio behaviour - UI scale or text size - Screen shake toggle - Flashing effects reduction - Brightness only if the game can control it meaningfully

Accessibility - Text size and contrast - Reduced motion / screen shake - Colour-independent status indicators - Clear status-effect icons plus labels - Adjustable timing or hold requirements where possible - Subtitles / dialogue presentation if voice is present - Haptic feedback toggle - Avoid reliance on colour alone to signal danger, rarity or selection

Data - Save status / last save - Cloud or local save status, if applicable - Credits - Privacy / analytics disclosures if relevant - Reset options with explicit warning and confirmation

12.2 Settings UX rules

- Group settings by player intent, not by implementation detail.
- Make changes apply immediately where safe and show feedback.
- Distinguish "Reset this category" from "Reset all settings".
- Never place destructive save/reset actions beside common actions without protection.
- Use plain language and explain unusual options.
- Persist settings across launches.
- Keep controller navigation functional in Settings.
- Ensure audio sliders can be changed without sudden jumps.
- Test settings on small screens and with long translations if applicable.

12.3 Save and recovery

Audit saving early. Players need confidence that progress is safe.

- Make it clear whether saving is automatic or manual.
- Show a discreet save indicator when a save is in progress.
- Avoid saving in a half-resolved battle or transition state.
- Handle app backgrounding, force-close and device restart safely.
- Test low-storage and interrupted-write scenarios where feasible.
- Explain any restrictions on saving.
- Never report "Saved" before the save operation has succeeded.
- Provide a clear recovery path if a save cannot be loaded.

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13. Progression, difficulty and rewards

A good RPG lets players understand how they are growing and gives them meaningful reasons to continue.

13.1 Progression layers

Keep the roles of these layers distinct:

- **Story progression:** what major events and places become available.
- **Player progression:** skills, capabilities or general advancement.
- **Creature progression:** new moves, evolution, mastery or other game-specific growth.
- **World progression:** new routes, services, NPC states and shortcuts.
- **Collection progression:** new discoveries and catalogue knowledge.
- **Home / Rep progression:** personal investment and social standing.

The layers should reinforce one another, but avoid requiring the player to grind one unrelated system to advance another.

13.2 Reward quality

Audit rewards by asking what they change:

- Does the reward solve a current problem?
- Does it open a new strategy or route?
- Does it deepen a character or location?
- Does it make the world more understandable?
- Does it support a personal goal?
- Is it appropriately valuable for the effort?

Currency and generic experience are useful, but not every quest should end with the same reward type.

13.3 Difficulty signalling

- Introduce new mechanics in low-risk contexts.
- Show danger through the world before punishing the player.
- Make boss and major encounter expectations legible.
- Allow preparation and strategy to matter.
- Avoid requiring one specific creature or build unless the game has clearly taught that requirement.
- If the player loses, explain what happened and offer a sensible retry path.
- Do not make ordinary travel a repeated tax on failure.

13.4 Avoid meaningless grind

Repetition is acceptable when it supports mastery, collection, a deliberate challenge or a satisfying routine. It is harmful when players repeat a task only because the game withholds the next meaningful activity behind an arbitrary counter.

Track where the player is asked to repeat content and ask whether the repetition is enjoyable in itself.

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14. Full audit checklist

Use this section as the practical test plan. Mark each item **Pass**, **Partial**, **Fail** or **Not tested** against a specific APK version and device. Do not mark an item as passed based on intention or a mock-up alone.

A. World and travel

- [ ] The player understands the overall world structure.
- [ ] The current location is always identifiable.
- [ ] Main routes connect places in a coherent, explainable way.
- [ ] Every major destination has a clear reason to visit.
- [ ] First-time travel contains orientation and discovery.
- [ ] Return travel is efficient once the route is learned.
- [ ] Fast travel only targets valid, discovered locations unless intentionally designed otherwise.
- [ ] Locked paths explain the reason or provide a clue.
- [ ] Map markers match actual entrances and exits.
- [ ] The player cannot become permanently lost or trapped through normal play.
- [ ] High-risk areas provide fair signals.
- [ ] Story changes are reflected in the world.
- [ ] Routes have distinct identities.
- [ ] No quest depends on a hidden, undocumented travel rule.

B. Exploration and environments

- [ ] Every major area has a unique visual and gameplay identity.
- [ ] Landmarks are visible and memorable.
- [ ] Optional paths offer meaningful rewards.
- [ ] Collectibles and resources are placed with intent.
- [ ] Caves have understandable spatial layouts.
- [ ] Cave rooms do not feel interchangeable.
- [ ] Environmental storytelling supports the location’s theme.
- [ ] Revisited areas offer new opportunities when appropriate.
- [ ] Navigation does not rely exclusively on UI markers.
- [ ] Camera, collision and movement support precise navigation.
- [ ] Entrances, exits and interactables are easy to recognise.
- [ ] Performance remains stable while exploring.

C. Creatures and collection

- [ ] Creatures have distinct roles and identities.
- [ ] Habitats make sense in the world.
- [ ] New creatures are discoverable through clues or observation.
- [ ] The collection journal explains useful information clearly.
- [ ] Discovery and ownership states are unambiguous.
- [ ] Team changes are easy to make.
- [ ] Creature information is accessible before important decisions.
- [ ] No single strategy dominates all ordinary encounters.
- [ ] Weak or early creatures can retain a purpose.
- [ ] Creature art, animation and effects are readable at device scale.

D. Battles

- [ ] Battle start clearly communicates the encounter.
- [ ] Turn order and available actions are obvious.
- [ ] Target selection is clear.

- [ ] Status effects are explained.
- [ ] Action outcomes are readable.
- [ ] Animation timing respects player control.
- [ ] Battle feedback is consistent.
- [ ] Victory and defeat resolve correctly.
- [ ] Rewards are clear and proportionate.
- [ ] The player can complete every battle using Backbone only.
- [ ] Battle UI scales to long names and unusual states.
- [ ] Repeated battles do not become unnecessarily slow.

E. Story and quests

- [ ] The main objective is understandable.
- [ ] Quest descriptions include useful location clues.
- [ ] The journal records progress reliably.
- [ ] Quest completion is clearly communicated.
- [ ] NPCs have identifiable roles and motivations.
- [ ] Characters and places respond to important events.
- [ ] Side quests reveal something about the world or its systems.
- [ ] Optional quests remain optional unless explicitly signalled.
- [ ] Quest rewards are meaningful and varied.
- [ ] The player can recover context after a long break.

F. Towns and buildings

- [ ] Important services are recognisable from the exterior.
- [ ] Buildings match their functions.
- [ ] Different settlements have distinct layouts and identities.
- [ ] Homes vary without losing the game’s visual language.
- [ ] Interiors reinforce the service or character.
- [ ] NPC placement and movement feel plausible.
- [ ] Town navigation is clear.
- [ ] Entering and leaving buildings is consistent.
- [ ] Services explain cost, effects and requirements.
- [ ] Important buildings are not visually hidden by clutter.

G. UI and information architecture

- [ ] Every screen has one clear primary purpose.
- [ ] Back and close behaviour is consistent.
- [ ] The player can always identify the current menu context.
- [ ] Important actions are not buried in deep menus.
- [ ] Journal categories are easy to distinguish.
- [ ] Active objectives are easy to find.
- [ ] Empty, loading, error and success states exist where needed.
- [ ] Text remains readable on a phone.
- [ ] UI scale and safe areas are handled.
- [ ] Focus and selection are visible.
- [ ] Modals do not stack unnecessarily.
- [ ] UI transitions do not hide important feedback.

H. Controls and Backbone

- [ ] Movement is consistent across input methods.
- [ ] All interactive screens can be used without touch.
- [ ] Controller focus is always visible.
- [ ] Back/cancel closes the topmost layer first.
- [ ] Focus restores sensibly when menus close.
- [ ] No action double-triggers through stick repeat.
- [ ] Long lists scroll correctly.
- [ ] Controller connection loss is handled safely.
- [ ] On-screen prompts reflect the active input mode.
- [ ] Settings can be fully navigated with the controller.
- [ ] Battle, inventory, map and journal are controller-complete.
- [ ] Actual Backbone hardware has been tested.

I. Settings and accessibility

- [ ] Settings are grouped by player intent.
- [ ] Audio categories work and persist.
- [ ] Text and interface scale are readable.
- [ ] Reduced motion options exist where needed.
- [ ] Status and selection are not communicated by colour alone.
- [ ] Vibration can be disabled if supported.
- [ ] Changes provide immediate feedback.
- [ ] Reset actions are protected.
- [ ] Settings persist after force-close and relaunch.
- [ ] Accessibility options are tested, not merely present.

J. Save, stability and performance

- [ ] Save behaviour is clear.
- [ ] Save state is not corrupted by interrupted transitions.
- [ ] App backgrounding and resume work.
- [ ] Force-close recovery works.
- [ ] No softlocks after battle, dialogue or travel.
- [ ] Loading and transition states are handled.
- [ ] Memory use remains stable over a long session.
- [ ] Asset loading does not cause missing or flickering visuals.
- [ ] Repeated screens do not leak state or duplicate UI.
- [ ] Low-storage and failed-save behaviour is understandable.
- [ ] Progress is retained across app restart.
- [ ] Performance is tested on representative Android devices.

K. Audio and feedback

- [ ] Locations have distinct ambience where appropriate.
- [ ] Important actions have clear sound or visual feedback.
- [ ] Music supports the mood and changes at meaningful moments.
- [ ] Audio levels are balanced across exploration, dialogue and battle.
- [ ] Important information is not conveyed by sound alone.

- [ ] Repeated effects do not become irritating.
- [ ] Music and effects settings persist.

L. Content consistency

- [ ] Terminology is consistent across UI, dialogue and journal.
- [ ] Item, creature and location names match everywhere.
- [ ] Art style is consistent across backgrounds, buildings, icons and battle screens.
- [ ] Every new asset has a clear purpose and correct scale.
- [ ] Reused assets do not erase location identity.
- [ ] Text fits all supported screen sizes.
- [ ] Tutorial language matches actual controls.
- [ ] Content updates do not break old saves.

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15. Prioritised improvement roadmap

Do not attempt to fix everything at once. Stabilise the core loop, then improve content depth, then polish.

Phase 0 — Establish a verified baseline

Goal: Know what the current build actually does before redesigning it.

1. Select the exact APK to audit and record its version/build hash.
2. Play a complete first-time path from the opening through the first major progression milestone.
3. Record every location transition and why it occurs.
4. Capture screens for the world map, travel transitions, journal, inventory, battle, settings and every major service.
5. Test touch and Backbone separately.
6. Log bugs separately from design issues.
7. Mark the Section 14 checklist with evidence.

Deliverables: baseline audit, route graph, screen inventory, control map, issue log and a short list of the five highest-impact problems.

Phase 1 — Fix the adventure spine

Goal: Make the game feel like a coherent journey.

1. Draw the world graph and document every major connection.
2. Define the expected travel rules.
3. Fix confusing or arbitrary location transitions.
4. Improve destination clues, landmarks and route identity.
5. Make the map and journal agree with the world.
6. Ensure every main quest explains where to go and why.
7. Add fast travel only where it supports the chosen world model.

Exit criteria: a new player can explain the route to the next main destination; returning travel is not tedious; all major quest destinations are reachable and understandable.

Phase 2 — Make exploration rewarding

Goal: Turn routes and interiors into places worth remembering.

1. Give each major region a distinct visual identity.
2. Rework the most repetitive cave and mine layouts.
3. Add meaningful optional branches and shortcuts.
4. Tie creatures, resources, finds and quests to local ecology.
5. Make revisit opportunities clear and rewarding.
6. Improve the environmental storytelling of major landmarks.

Exit criteria: each major area has a distinct identity and at least one memorable discovery or decision.

Phase 3 — Connect the systems

Goal: Make the journal, quests, people, creatures, home and Rep reinforce one another.

1. Define what each journal category is for.
2. Add cross-links between related entries.
3. Ensure NPCs and locations respond to key story events.
4. Make creature discoveries useful beyond catalogue completion.
5. Make Home upgrades visibly change the player's experience.
6. Make Rep produce understandable, worthwhile world reactions.
7. Audit quest rewards and remove repetitive filler.

Exit criteria: major activities contribute to more than one meaningful system without creating confusing duplication.

Phase 4 — Standardise UI and input

Goal: Remove friction from routine play.

1. Audit every screen using Section 10.
2. Standardise navigation, Back, focus and modal rules.
3. Implement a canonical input action map.
4. Complete Backbone-only navigation for all essential flows.
5. Rework settings and accessibility categories.
6. Improve save-state communication and recovery.
7. Test on small screens and actual target devices.

Exit criteria: a player can complete the main loop without accidental dead ends, forced touch input or confusing menu behaviour.

Phase 5 — Combat, balance and presentation

Goal: Make battles clear, tactically interesting and satisfying.

1. Test battle readability at real device scale.
2. Audit action economy, creature roles and dominant strategies.
3. Tune animation speed and feedback.
4. Make status, target and turn information clear.
5. Validate victory, defeat, rewards and return-to-world transitions.
6. Test the entire battle flow with Backbone.

Exit criteria: players understand outcomes, have meaningful decisions and can complete battles with their preferred input method.

Phase 6 — Content and polish

Goal: Make the whole game feel intentionally authored.

1. Improve building silhouettes and interiors.
2. Refine music, ambience and action feedback.
3. Remove redundant tutorials and repeated dialogue.
4. Standardise naming, icons, typography and spacing.
5. Run long-session, save/resume and regression tests.
6. Re-audit the full checklist after each substantial release.

Exit criteria: visual, audio, interaction and narrative systems feel consistent rather than separately bolted together.

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16. How to measure whether the redesign works

Use observed behaviour, not personal preference alone. A small test with five players can reveal major navigation issues.

Suggested playtest tasks

1. Start a new game and reach the first major destination.
2. Explain the route taken and why.
3. Find a healing service without using trial and error.
4. Locate a quest objective using only the journal and world clues.
5. Discover an optional area.
6. Identify a building’s purpose from its exterior.
7. Find information about a creature encountered earlier.
8. Change a relevant setting.
9. Complete a battle using Backbone only.
10. Save, close and relaunch the game; confirm progress.
11. Return to a known location.
12. Explain what the player is working towards next.

Metrics and signals

- Time to understand the next main objective
- Number of wrong turns or unnecessary menu openings
- Number of times a tester asks “Where do I go?”
- Number of interactions that require a second input method
- Percentage of testers who can identify important services
- Percentage of testers who notice an optional discovery
- Number of softlocks, lost states or unexplained transitions
- Frequency of unnecessary backtracking
- Player recall of locations after a short break
- Whether players can describe a creature’s role or a town’s identity

Do not optimise purely for speed. A longer route can be good if it is interesting. The goal is **intentional time**, not minimum time.

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17. Implementation rules for Claude or another coding partner

Use this as the engineering guardrail when implementing the audit.

Required workflow

1. **Inspect before changing.** Trace the current implementation and identify the relevant screens, state, routes, save data and input handling.
2. **Report the current behaviour.** Explain what happens today and where it is implemented.
3. **Propose a small change.** State the intended behaviour, affected files and risk.
4. **Implement in a focused stage.** Avoid rewriting unrelated systems.
5. **Test the full flow.** Test both the happy path and cancellation, failure, relaunch and controller cases.
6. **Show evidence.** Provide screenshots, a short test report and the changed files.
7. **Update the design record.** Keep the world graph, action map and audit checklist current.
8. **Protect saves.** Do not change save schema or progression assumptions without migration and regression tests.

Engineering principles

- Use one source of truth for location connections and travel eligibility.
- Use stable IDs for locations, creatures, quests, items and journal records.
- Keep UI labels separate from internal IDs.
- Make map, journal and quest destination data agree.
- Centralise input actions so touch and Backbone trigger the same game actions.
- Use reusable UI patterns without making every screen identical.
- Make state transitions explicit; avoid hidden state changes tied to screen rendering.
- Add logging for failed transitions, missing destinations and invalid save data.
- Do not silently swallow errors.
- Avoid adding settings that have no implemented effect.
- Do not mark a feature complete until it has been tested in the actual APK.

Suggested implementation prompt

> Review `WILDCARD_FULL_GAME_AUDIT.md` and the current Wildcard source/APK. Do not begin by changing code. First produce a verified baseline for Phase 0: map the current world/location graph, document how travel works, list every main screen and its navigation behaviour, identify the actual touch and Backbone input paths, and record save/settings behaviour. Separate verified facts from assumptions. Then recommend the five highest-impact fixes with evidence, dependencies, risks and acceptance criteria. Implement only after I approve the staged plan. Preserve existing working features and save compatibility. For every stage, include changed files, before/after screenshots where relevant, and tests for normal use, cancellation, errors, app resume and Backbone-only operation.

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18. Decisions to make before adding more features

Answer these as design decisions and document the outcomes:

1. Is Wildcard primarily a route-based adventure, a hub-and-expedition game, or a seamless open world?
2. What is the intended emotional promise: discovery, creature attachment, tactical battles, story, home-building, social reputation or a deliberate blend?
3. What is the main 10-minute gameplay loop?
4. What should a player usually be doing between major story events?
5. How much freedom should players have to visit dangerous locations early?
6. What is the role of the world map versus walking through the world?
7. Which actions should be available instantly, and which should require a trip to a settlement?
8. What makes a creature worth discovering beyond its combat strength?
9. What makes a town memorable beyond the services it provides?
10. What does Rep change in the world?
11. What is the reason to return Home?
12. What must be possible with Backbone only?
13. What is the minimum acceptable save/recovery behaviour?
14. Which features are essential to the core game, and which can be deferred?

Do not add systems to answer all these questions at once. Establish the core identity first.

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19. Final recommendation

Wildcard does not need to become a Pokémon clone. It needs the same level of intentionality that makes a great creature adventure work.

Fix the world before expanding it. Make travel logical, routes memorable, destinations understandable and returns purposeful. Then connect exploration to creatures, people, quests, finds, home and reputation. After that, standardise the interface, settings and controls so the player can focus on the adventure instead of fighting the game.

The most useful first deliverable is a **verified world graph and first-hour walkthrough**, followed by the top five issues ranked by player impact. That will expose whether the central problem is geography, quest direction, progression, interface friction or a combination. Use those findings to guide staged implementation rather than asking a coding assistant to “improve everything” in one pass.

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20. Reference notes

These public reviews and official materials informed the comparison principles. They are references for design analysis, not claims that Wildcard should reproduce Pokémon’s exact systems.

- **Official Pokémon Scarlet and Pokémon Violet overview** — describes a freely explorable world with towns blending into the wilderness and visible creatures across environments: https://www.pokemon.com/uk/pokemon-video-games/pokemon-scarlet-and-pokemon-violet
- **GameSpot — Pokémon Legends: Arceus review** — discusses field research, the centrality of discovery, flexible exploration and the downside of grind-heavy progression gates: https://www.gamespot.com/reviews/pokemon-legends-arceus-review-what-pokemon-is-evolving/1900-6417818/
- **GameSpot — Pokémon Scarlet & Violet review** — highlights the freedom of branching progression and the strengths and weaknesses of open-world exploration: https://www.gamespot.com/reviews/pokemon-scarlet-violet-review-a-braviary-new-world/1900-6417994/

- **Kotaku — Pokémon Scarlet and Violet review** — critiques the loss of specific, memorable route identities and the navigational weakness of a broad but less distinctive world: https://kotaku.com/pokemon-scarlet-and-violet-review-nintendo-switch-1849843125
- **Nintendo Life — Pokémon Legends: Arceus review** — emphasises exploration, discovery, creature interactions and a compelling sense of scale: https://www.nintendolife.com/reviews/nintendo-switch/pokemon-legends-arceus

How to interpret this audit

- **Verified project context:** Wildcard has the named journal categories; prior work flagged repeated cave-room templates, visually repetitive buildings, battle-scene work and Backbone support as relevant concerns.
- **User-reported concern:** travel between places feels logically off.
- **Design hypotheses:** other gaps listed above must be confirmed in the current build.
- **Recommended standard:** every issue should eventually have a reproducible example, severity, player impact, proposed fix and acceptance test.

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21. Recommendations for the current build (3.32.1)

This section checks the audit against what build 3.32.1 actually does, using the source, the automated tests and `docs/STORY_AND_PROGRESSION.md` / `docs/WORLD.md`. **Verified** means the code and a passing test show it. **Not verified** means it has only been checked in a desktop browser or not checked at all. Nothing here has been played on a real phone with a real Backbone.

21.1 Where the build already meets the audit

Audit item	Status in 3.32.1	Evidence
World graph, one source of truth (4.2, 17)	**Verified**	`G.WORLD` (24 places, 36 land routes, 5 ferries); `docs/STORY_AND_PROGRESSION.md` is checked against the game by `tests/e2e-guide.js`
Locked paths explain why (4.3, 14A)	**Verified**	badges + chapter rule in `js/access.js`; the gate names the chapter or badge count; money cannot buy access
Routes between towns (4.1)	**Partly**	4 wild roads added where towns touched directly; other links go straight into large wild regions
Fast travel after discovery (4.1)	**Verified**	flight and helicopter go only to visited places, and ferries respect the gate rule
Distinct caves (5.2)	**Partly**	Glimmer Mine rebuilt and four new caves with themes and puzzles; older rooms still share templates
Battle readability (7.1)	**Partly**	new HUD: status panels, one-row commands, move cards with type/power/PP, target ring, low-HP state; desktop screenshots only

Audit item	Status in 3.32.1	Evidence
Controller complete (11, 14H)	**Partly**	Gamepad API + Android native input, remapping, hide-touch-buttons; **real Backbone not tested**
Settings grouped, reduced motion, colour-friendly HP (12)	**Verified**	Settings screen and `docs/SETTINGS.md`; `tests/e2e-settings.js`
Save slots (12.3)	**Partly**	slots and CONTINUE tested; interrupted writes, backgrounding and low storage not tested

21.2 Top five fixes, ranked by player impact

1. **Do the Phase 0 baseline on a real phone and the real Backbone (audit 15, Phase 0).** The biggest unknown is not design but the device. Play the opening to the Keystone Badge on your phone, touch only, then again with the Backbone only. Log every place where you had to touch the screen, every unclear exit and every softlock. *Acceptance:* checklist sections A, D, H and J marked Pass/Partial/Fail with screenshots.

2. **Make the next step obvious at every moment (4.5, 8.1, 14E).** The quest tracker shows the objective, but not *where* in words a player can act on. Add the destination's place name and direction to every main-quest step ("Go south from Lanternrest along Stonebridge Road"). Add a "where next" line to the map screen, and mark the destination on the map. *Acceptance:* a new player can reach each chapter's destination without asking "where do I go?".

3. **Give the new spaces a reason to exist (5.3, 5.4, 8.2).** The four roads and seven sea islands are walkable but only hold trainers, items and flavour lines. Give each one small beat that ties into the story or the journal: a Finds entry, a rare creature only found there, a character who appears again later, or a shortcut that opens after a chapter. *Acceptance:* every road and island has at least one discovery recorded in the journal.

4. **Make later chapters longer and harder by design, not just by level (13, audit item "harder or longer").** The step counts are 5, 5, 5, 6, 4, 5, 4, 3, so chapters 5 to 8 get *shorter*. Add two or three objectives to each of them, spread across the cities already open: a trust encounter, a cave visit, a person to find. Check that no story battle needs a specific creature the game has not taught. *Acceptance:* the step count rises chapter by chapter, and wild levels and Arena strength rise steadily (the guide already shows the levels).

5. **Battle flow speed and clarity on a phone (7.2, 7.3, 14D).** Test a full battle on the phone. Check that the cards are big enough to tap, that the message bar does not need too many A presses, and that status effects say what they do in plain words. Consider adding a short "why" to failed moves ("It doesn't affect…" already exists; add one for missed and immune cases). Fill the portrait sky above the arena with something better than a gradient, or move the scene down. *Acceptance:* a battle can be finished with the Backbone alone, and no state is hidden behind the HUD at phone size.

21.3 Next after those

- **Towns and buildings (9):** check that the heal, shop, forge and Arena buildings are recognisable before reading the label. This has not been audited since the building work.
- **Journal cross-links (8.7):** a creature or Finds entry should link to the place where it was found.

- **Rep (8.6):** say on screen what reputation changes (discounts, new dialogue, access) when a milestone is reached.
- **Save safety (12.3):** test force-close in the middle of a battle and during a map transition, and test resuming after the app is backgrounded.
- **Balance (6.3):** run a quick check that no single creature or move dominates ordinary battles.

21.4 Decisions only the owner can make (from section 18)

1. Route-based adventure, hub-and-expedition, or open world? The current build is route-based with an open sea. Keep that?
2. How much should a player be able to visit dangerous places early? The current rule is badges + chapter, with no way round it.
3. Should Test Mode keep NO BATTLES, FLY ANYWHERE and UNLOCK EVERYTHING in the shipped APK?
4. What is the reason to return Home? Farming and building exist, but no story beat sends you back.

21.5 Suggested order

Phase 0 baseline (item 1) → quest direction (2) → chapter length (4) → road/island beats (3) → battle on device (5) → section 21.3. Each step should end with the full test suite green, an APK and a short evidence report, as section 17 asks.